

ANI



SAMIR JANA/GETTY IMAGES





PTI

(Clockwise from left) Protests over murder of student leader Anish Khan; Mamata Banerjee at an iftar party; scene of the Bagtui carnage; a Hanskhali rape case accused

It is meant to bolster her empathetic image too. When it was introduced first after the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, the TMC was reeling under allegations of 'cut money' (bribes to TMC leaders for delivering government schemes).

Mamata's controlling hand is seen in changes in the working template of TMC's decision making bodies. Though young leaders have grouped around Abhishek, Mamata has shown that she has the last say. The way she dissolved the 20-member national working committee in February and came up with a new one, picking her trusted men and creating posts—'coordinator' Firhad Hakim, for instance, is to liaise with chairperson Mamata and other members—is a case in point. Again, in a state committee meeting on May 5, she reinstated loyalists Ajit Maiti and Dilip Yadav in West Medinipur and Hooghly districts, sidelining the youth leaders installed by Abhishek. However, Mamata has to tackle the tricky matter of succession in future.

Party matters apart, Mamata needs to focus on governance. With less than a year left for the panchayat polls—the crucial building block of area domination in rural Bengal—she will need to ensure that her government had met demands. In a series of tours to the districts (she was in Paschim Medinipur and Jhargram recently), she will hold meetings with panchayat workers. Anger against local leaders runs high on the old issue of bribes and extortion, and Mamata has asked people to go to the police, even write to her. "I don't know if any party president, like Sonia Gandhi or J.P. Nadda, have gone or will go to the grassroots to connect with panchayat and block-level workers," says TMC Rajya Sabya MP Sukhendu Shekhar Ray. Now, for transparency, panchayats are being kept outside the purview of giving tenders to contractors. Welfare schemes are important for Mamata's governance. The annual expense is around Rs 25,000 crore, but Mamata has widened the net of beneficiaries of *Lakshmir Bhandar* (monthly income support for families) scheme from 15 million to 17.5 million as well as that of *Kanyashree* (education stipend for girls).

As for employment generation, the CM has started a programme of recruiting 6,000 educated youths in government departments. However, her ambitious target of employment for 1.5 crore people in the next four years can only be met with industrialisation. Towards this, the commitment of Adani Group chief Gautam Adani to invest Rs 10,000 crore over the next decade in West Bengal, announced at the Bengal Global Business Summit, is significant. "If Adani comes, can other industry captains be far behind?" asks a bureaucrat.

A year into her third term, Mamata is personally invested in enforcing discipline and dragging Trinamool out of its complacent rut. The situation can still be saved. ■